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Title:
AN INTROVERT'S GUIDE TO QUARANTINE

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Published by
MUSHROOM CLOUD PRESS
U.S.A.

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An Introvert's Guide to Quarantine

By Mike Noland

I know you are going to think I'm crazy and maybe I am, don't answer that but I have actually... kind of liked being in quarantine. Now let's face it, this virus is awful and I don't want anyone to get it and certainly not die from it. The world right now is more scary and dangerous than it's been in a long time. Like maybe since the dinosaurs or the Middle Ages or the height of the Black Friday sales events at the mall and the only safe place to be is home. I like being home so that's why I like being quarantined.

I have to admit, I've always liked being at home because I'm an introvert. There, I said it, whew. It's like a weight has been lifted from me. Being an introvert in high school is not an easy thing. Everyone expects you to be out doing stuff. "Hey Denny/ Jenny, we are all going to Paula's house to watch the football game, wanna come?" or "Denny/Jenny, we're gonna play Farmville and then take selfies with Pattie's hedgehog." I don't want to do anything of that, but hedgehogs are kinda cool. I love being in my room listening to music or reading a book or just playing mindless games on my

phone. Why is that such a weird thing? Don't get me wrong, I like people, well..most people...well, actually only a few people and I have friends. At school, most people are like "You are so funny, we should hang out more." I think to myself, "Mmmm, no." I just get tired of always having to be "on", ya know? When you are at school people expect you to act a certain way. That gets old by the end of the day, heck that gets old by the end of first period. So going home is a much needed respite from the world.

Now with the quarantine, nobody is doing anything, Yes! That takes a ton of pressure off of me. I don't have to make excuses for not going anywhere and I don't...like...feel bad. Why is everybody freaking out about it? I do think it's weird that people started buying up all the toilet paper and guns. Toilet paper kind of sort of makes sense, but guns? You can't shoot the virus. I guess people were getting guns to protect all the toilet paper they bought. For me, this was a chance to chill and take a deep, cleansing breath. People just need to see the good side of all of this.

For example, you can wear the same clothes all day everyday. That is amazing. It's so freeing, I love it. Not that clothes and image are that big of a deal to me

anyway but it's nice to just bum around the house in sweats and a t-shirt from morning till night. My mom got mad "DENNY/JENNY, you haven't changed clothes since Monday?" I said, "Uh, yeah, and it's only Thursday, what's your point? Unless Beyonce is dropping by to take me out for a caramel cinnamon dolce latte, I think my clothes are just fine." She doesn't get it because she has taken a shower and put on makeup everyday. Seriously, what is wrong with her? She's not fooling anyone with that makeup anyway because 40 is not the new 20! Fortunately my dad has been much cooler about it. I think he loves not wearing a suit and tie everyday. Unless he has a video call then it's business up top and pj's downtown.

Numero dos, that's number two in Spanish. I might as well keep in practice since it's still one of my courses. Anyway, I don't have to go to school. Bing, Bing, Bing, that's a winner, winner, chicken dinner every time. That doesn't mean I don't have school, it just means I don't have to go. I get to do all my school work from home. It has its ups and downs, but overall, I'm loving it. I'm still doing plenty of work without the social pressure, bullying, snide remarks and those are usually coming from me. Being in a school building is like a lab experiment and we

are all the rats. We are forced into close quarters with people that in the outside world we would never even speak to, at least I wouldn't. Then they run us through a maze and make us do tasks for our treats. Good grades being the ultimate reward. I know there are some people who love school like Avery. "Mr. Allen, would it be possible to get extra credit if I organized your books in your bookshelf by color? That would really be so gorg to look at." She's a literal freak show. If you are an introvert like me, school is pretty much the 7th level of Hell. What's really strange is I love the academic side of it. Getting to learn new things is exciting and being able to do it using my laptop from home is...bliss. I know that many kids won't agree with me, but here are a few of my reasons why I love quarantining, they can make their own list. Ya know, list better have my reasons. (Laughs softly, then stops.)

Another fab thing is Streaming. There's no point lying about it. Streaming shows, movies and even videos has been incredible. Let me say that I have always been a fan of going to the movies, sitting in the dark with a box of popcorn and a coke and losing myself in that magical experience. Except for the dimwit that shouts, "Dude, he's behind the door." With the ability to watch at home on a screen that's as big as my dad's first car, his words

not mine, who needs the aggravation? I can binge on Netflix, Hulu, HBO and Disney. I'm just naming a few because the list gets longer every day. Imagine if we had to quarantine 50 years ago when they only had, like 4 channels to watch and one of them was PBS, eewww. That would have been tough. No worries, we are living in the age of Stream- topia. It's perfect for our times and I couldn't be happier about it. With all this stuff to watch, why does anyone want to leave their house? If I can't sleep, I'll watch some Youtube, need a study break, I'll catch some AppleTV. It's the perfect solution anytime. I've even watched some of those cooking shows which leads me to my next point.

My mom has been baking breads like crazy. "Mom", I said "are we expecting company?" She looks confused and says "No, why?" "Well, unless you got a side hustle with Pepperidge Farm, it seems like you've baked an excessive amount of bread." She got a little defensive and said, "No it's not, you're just being judgmental." I said, "Am I? I went to the hall closet to get a towel and 2 loaves of bread fell on my head." "Get out of my kitchen" she said as she took a swing at me with a whisk. However, others benefit from her overzealous culinary coping mechanism. She gave the FedEx guy banana bread, the mail carrier got zucchini bread and our

neighbor, with the yappy little dog that poops in everybody's yard, got brownies. (Laughs) Now that was a good one. Every night, mom is trying some kind of new dish that she came across. Some of it's kinda weird but all of it is good. I think I have gained my "Quarantine 15" as they say. Since I'm living in sweatpants it's not a problem. I don't really care if I end up a Fatty-boom-ba-latty, it's not like it's forever, right Jenny Craig?

Let me ask, are you getting enough sleep? Because as teenagers we never seem to get enough and if we do we get yelled at. I have never understood that because there's mountains of evidence out there proving that teenagers require lots of sleep,.. duh! But I get treated like I sucker punched a baby seal, if I sleep more than 8 hours. "You gonna sleep the whole weekend or I was just checking on you for signs of life," my parents say. Yet when my dad goes to sleep in the living room watching tv, he always says, "I wasn't sleeping, I was just resting my eyes." Thanks to quarantine, sleep is not a dirty word. I've settled into a nice little pattern. I stay up late, but now I can sleep late. Not only that but I have discovered the joys of napping. How have I been missing this my whole life? I used to make fun of my Grandpa Morris when he came to visit. That man could start snoring before he got the footrest up on the La-Z- Boy. I

just thought it was an old person thing but was I ever wrong. It's a sweet little nugget that never disappoints.

I can just hear some of you now, "but Denny/Jenny I'm not enjoying quarantine at all. If I have to stay in this house with my family for one more minute, I'll die, I'll just die." While I appreciate good hyperbole, you just need to step back from the ledge. It's not that bad. Believe me, if you have friends, they will look really good to you after a few months cooped up with the fam. Quarantining is not that easy, but it doesn't have to be that hard either. So phone on, shoes off and quarantine like me, the introvert!